

It has been said that cooperativism is an economic movement that is also educational. We might say the reverse as well: that cooperativism is an educational movement that utilizes economic action.

– Jose Maria Arizmendiarieta, founder of the Mondragón cooperative experience

Who will develop these new paradigms and a new economic ideology? Who will mentor students to become paradigm changers and scholar activists? How will they learn about and understand the attempts in the past, the past models of success, and the lessons of the failures? We are not training our youth to think creatively or to think outside of the traditional economic.”

– Jessica Gordon Nembhard PhD

We are not educated to be democratic in schools...we're really not educated to be fully participatory, fully engaged in our economic life from childhood. When we go to school, we're trained to be an owner, you want to either be a worker or the owner... Well, imagine if we've taught our young people to both be entrepreneurial - think of great ideas - but work collectively...how about if we could win collectively?

– Stacey Sutton PhD

Economic Democracy means involving the community, especially historically marginalized groups, in the ownership and decision making of the economic, social, financial institutions and resources of society. It shifts power in a way that produces meaningful changes in the lives of those involved. As an educator, I would like my students to be empowered with the knowledge and the means to shape their futures and the future of their communities.

– Bruce Karhoff, Teacher at Bronx Lab High School and Mentor to Fellows

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Overview of the Case

The Bronx Cooperative Development Initiative (BCDI), a community-led economic development organization committed to shared wealth and ownership with low-income people of color, co-created a yearlong fellowship on education and economic democracy for Bronx teachers and students at five borough high schools in 2022. After a multi-year planning process working with allies, we invited five teachers and 13 high school students to explore how high schools can support economic democracy in the Bronx as Economic Democracy Schools Fellows. This document provides the background and chronology of these efforts over the past 4 years.

In 2018, a youth organizer from Sistas and Brothas United, the youth organizing group affiliated with Northwest Bronx Community and Clergy Coalition, returned from a visit to Mondragón. In addition to the democratic workplaces, the bank, and the university, their delegation included some time spent at the *Ikastolas*, the less well-known schools in the Mondragón network that shape the cooperative and cultural attitudes of the regional community in their youth. In a report back to a small group of peers in the Bronx, she commented that the *Ikastolas* were great, course, but that when young people in the Bronx have organized for their schools to look more like the Mondragón *Ikastolas*, “here they treat us like criminals instead.” The depth of this analysis, and the implications for our work in the United States to build deeply multi-racial economic democracy, are profound. To quote [Daniel Perlstein](#), a scholar of the Black freedom movement’s educational practices,

*The history of the freedom and liberation schools developed by Black activists suggests that **no curricular project can fundamentally transform knowledge and its distribution if it is not part of a process of transforming social relations as well.***

The Bronx is home to a rich cooperative history, and with Cooperative Home Care Associates and Co-Op City, the largest worker and housing cooperatives in the country. Yet it is more often known as one of the poorest and least healthy urban counties in the state and country. Our task in the Fellowship was to draw on the history of community organizing for housing, economic, and educational justice and equity in the Bronx and develop a small cohort of educators and young people and collectively consider the role of youth and schools in present day organizing efforts for economic democracy in the Bronx. Throughout the calendar year, the fellows met with cooperators and organizers in



the Bronx and Manhattan, went on site visits, engaged in dialogue with guest speakers, and reflected on what they were seeing and learning by applying it back to the original question: **what is the role of high schools in supporting economic democracy in the Bronx?** By the end of the fellowship, our group collectively developed an understanding of how and where schools can create space for learning about, and practicing, deeper and more expansive democracy. These takeaways reflected what has been elsewhere described as school coherence: the alignment of school **culture, curricula, and community around a particular set of values and practices** (see [Knecht 2019](#)).

Economic Democracy: A Different Model of Economic and Human Development

In response to widening income inequality, housing insecurity and unaffordability, stagnant wages, and racialized wealth disparities, cities around the United States have recently begun studying and implementing models of shared democratic ownership such as worker cooperatives and community land trusts as strategies for equitable economic and community development. In the United States, cooperatives of various kinds have existed for generations, and have been a component of civil rights and economic justice movements throughout our history, as well as in community development practice, but they are often mostly marginal in terms of their prevalence in the mainstream practitioner and policymaking toolkit.

As such, advocates for cooperative economic development have often looked abroad to successful regional models of cooperative development ecosystems such as the Mondragón network in the Basque region of Spain, the Chantier social and solidarity economy development organization in Quebec, and the Emilia-Romagna complex of cooperatives and cooperative development organizations in northern Italy, among other examples. In their fullest expression, these examples of what is often labeled “economic democracy” or “community wealth” or “social/solidarity economies” represent a significant departure from the typical processes and outcomes of economic development in the United States. Most importantly, these regional democratic economies are strongly correlated with reduced socioeconomic inequality, greater social cohesion, and even subjective measures of happiness and well-being.

Organizers, philanthropy, social investors, entrepreneurs, and policymakers are studying these regional democratic economies, and have been adopting models of community wealth building in various ways in the United States. This has included discussions and concrete steps among educators to develop courses of study and curricula for professional education and development in disciplines such as policy, public administration, planning, law, and business school curricula.

We can learn from Mondragón and other examples on how education can facilitate the development of democratic capacities such as listening, compromise, empathy, and collaboration. Yet, a key element, the link between these pedagogies and durable, resilient cooperative economies has not been studied as it applies to advancing equitable urban economic development in the United States.



Our work at BCDI is based on the premise that fundamental changes in how our economy works, and for whom it works, require large scale institutional changes. [Only in the last few years](#) have community wealth building practitioners in the United States begun to articulate a clear need to develop an “upstream” K-12 component to our economic development work that addresses the technical, cultural, political, and economic skills and attitudes necessary to sustain a more democratic economy.

To be clear, this is not to be confused with the fact that school curricula on cooperatives have existed for decades. In our estimation, the missing link isn't that no curricular materials exist, it is that there has been insufficient work done to:

- 1) actively integrate these concepts and curricula into a broader cross-section of our multi-racial society, and
- 2) to apply them practically and holistically to the political and economic challenges of place-based community and economic development, particularly in low-income communities of color.

Other fellow travelers in very recent years in this work include Repaired Nations' [Work-Based Learning fellowship](#) with young people in Oakland, California, and the work of [Industrial Commons](#) in rural [North Carolina's Burke County](#). Developing Economic Democracy Fellowships in the Bronx is rooted in this context and challenge, and we are actively seeking to build together with allies across our city and the United States.

The Bronx Context

The Bronx is a place of immense contradictions; it is home to tremendous assets, including but not limited to the region's top hospitals and universities and the largest food distribution center in the country, yet remains the poorest urban county in the US. In the last half a century alone, Bronx residents have pioneered artistic revolutions, transformative political uprisings, and the largest worker and housing cooperatives in the country. But we have also faced extreme poverty, displacement, food insecurity, state violence, and environmental injustice.

Since the 1970s (and before), Bronx community leaders have been organizing to improve school conditions against tremendous systemic barriers and obstacles. From United Bronx Parents to Mothers on the Move to the Urban Youth Collaborative, the Parent Action Committee, Youth Ministries for Peace and Justice, Sistas and Brothas United, and The Point CDC, We Stay/Nos Quedamos, Banana Kelly Community Improvement Association, families, teachers, and young people have been crafted spaces to develop leaders, build movement, and fight back against structural racism locally and nationally.

In the face of these contradictions, we believe that the Bronx can be a leader in a more equitable urban future and transform the meaning of a good education that also prepares young people to lead us into a more sustainable future, where cooperation, civic responsibility and democracy are nurtured and reinforced inside and outside of the classroom. If the Bronx has proven anything it is that we have the resources, creativity, and the will to confront challenges and innovate community led solutions.

Economic democracy refers to people sharing ownership and control over the assets and resources in their communities. It means extending the principles of democracy that we supposedly cherish in the political sphere into the social and economic spheres of society. Specifically, it's about Bronxites **sharing ownership and wealth**, and **democratically controlling** the assets and resources in our borough. In the immediate moment and for the future, this means more resilience and solidarity - the things that we know are what keep us safe through all the tough times we have faced in the Bronx. Economic democracy will position Bronx residents and businesses as the collective decision-makers and owners of our borough's future. For public education, it not only places more control in the hands of students and community to govern their schools, it will also break the stale and unsustainable division between educating for economic



productivity and educating for civic and democratic skills and sensibilities. As [Doug Knecht from Bank Street College of Education](#) writes

“Even if high school graduates are anointed “college and career ready,” to what degree do students know how to be contributing members to American society if they are not actually practicing democracy as they grow and develop in school?”

To successfully share ownership and governance - to meaningfully exercise economic democracy - our schools must prepare young people to be ready for, and to lead, the democratic economy that we are co-constructing.

This gap between the Bronx’s assets and vulnerabilities has led community leaders and organizations to unite around a shared mission: to build a beloved community by developing shared ownership and democratic control over the major institutions and resources in our communities. **A consistent message from the five schools in our pilot and the community organizations we collaborated with was the need to strengthen school-community relations.** Our response to this is: **yes collaboration, towards what ends? Towards the ends of equitable development and shared community ownership of our neighborhoods.** We addressed this through practices and pedagogy of learning about economic democracy in Saturday workshops and visiting real-world examples of cooperatives bringing these approaches to life. This, in turn, centered our work, grounded our reflections, and enlivened our vision of economic democracy in the Bronx.

The Fellowship

To support the development of our vision for a more democratic and equitable Bronx, beginning in 2019, we worked with our partners The Point CDC, Northwest Bronx Community and Clergy Coalition, as well as a kitchen cabinet of advisors, researchers, educators, and young people to develop a yearlong **Economic Democracy Schools Fellowship**. After two years of research and iterative design, we came up with an experiment: a yearlong project-based program designed to support Bronx high schools to understand and apply principles and practices of economic democracy in and with their school communities.

The goal of this fellowship was to begin to build a community of learning and practice in service of a very ambitious but essential question: **what is the role of high schools in supporting economic democracy in the Bronx?** To answer that question, we recruited 13 students and five educators from five schools (Bronx Academy for Software Engineering, BASE; Comp-SCI; Bronx Lab; Leaders in Our Neighborhood, LION; and the Fannie Lou Hamer Freedom High School) who were invested in exploring the principles and history of economic democracy and committed to applying the lessons learned to their school communities in the Bronx. Fellows spent eight months studying:

1. The political and economic history of the Bronx;
2. The fundamentals of the Bronx economy; and
3. The history, legacy, and impact of Bronx cooperatives.
4. How to take our learning, and lessons and apply them to our schools curriculum, school culture and community.

This baseline of knowledge allowed fellows to interrogate and contextualize the principles that underlie economic democracy—cooperative principles, shared ownership, community action, and collective learning— and integrate those lessons into everyday school life.

Approach: In keeping with our commitment to institutional change and transformation, we approached this fellowship with **the school** as the unit of change, not the individual student. We also grounded the fellowship in a project-based learning approach, so that the connections made throughout the program would lead to usable end products that not only reflected learning, but could be used after the program ended in the schools to



continue the work. We took this approach because in our research we noticed that many attempts to advance cooperative education and economic democracy in schools have failed because they live only with a handful of interested people. The departure of a particular teacher or the graduation of a particular cohort of student leadership often ends these efforts. We wanted to design a program that invested in people, but ultimately transformed their schools into institutions that were coherently aligned to values, practices, and cultures of economic democracy.

Structure: Youth fellows committed to 80 hours over the course of eight months. They received training in concepts of economic democracy and equitable development, alongside on-site meetings with practitioners and entrepreneurs in equitable economic development. Students also received \$1,400 stipends, separated into three different gift cards dispersed throughout the program.

The school-based teacher mentors to the Fellows committed to 30 hours over the course of eight months, half of which were dedicated to project-based learning seminars. Educators did not receive a stipend but received either five hours of individualized coaching from a professional coach with years of experience supporting project-based and inquiry-driven learning, or paid registration to attend a Project Based Learning workshop series sponsored by PBLWorks, a nationally recognized training provider. All fellows were asked to deliver the following upon program completion:

- A personal reflective practice document in the form of their choosing to document their own learning and reflections on the experience of the fellowship
- A set of action steps, ideas, and proposals for their own school, or peer schools looking to build out practices of economic democracy.

Timeline: From concept to completion, the fellowship was a three-year project. From fall 2019 to fall 2021, the Bronx Cooperative Development Initiative designed the program in partnership with Bronx community leaders, students, researchers, and educators. This runway enabled BCDI to spend the time necessary to plan the program, support community responses to the COVID-19 pandemic, and adapt the program to a compelling, virtual format. **The program had three core phases: grounding and introduction, listening and learning, and synthesis and design.**



Concept Formation and Coalition Building (Pre-Fellowship)

Fall 2019

- BCDI and the Point CDC begin developing a curriculum for The Point's 9 month youth program ACTION.
- Comp Sci High approaches BCDI to initiate partnership around Fab Lab space and integrated innovation and social justice programming.

2020

- COVID suspends timeline for pilot activities but work moves ahead for fall 2020 virtual engagements.
- Through collaboration with BCDI, in the Fall of 2020 Comp Sci High screens Decade of Fire documentary and invites filmmaker Vivian Vasquez for virtual class visits.

Spring 2021

- BCDI partners for two session introduction to community wealth building as part of Comp Sci's post-secondary learning curriculum.
- BCDI works with MIT Community Innovators Lab to develop a field scan and interview partners on practices and thinking for how to craft a learning journey for economic democracy with youth. This includes two focus groups with educators, community organizations, and youth.



Grounding and Introduction (Fellowship Phase 1)

Fall 2021

- BCDI conducts info sessions with interested educators and begins outreach and recruitment.
- Schools applied to host fellows and nominated an educator in the fall. Final five schools were selected in December.

Winter/Spring 2022

- Youth fellow recruitment begins with school visits, zoom orientations, and outreach and recruitment from educators.
- March 2022: Fellowship begins with All Fellows Orientation (youth and educators).
- Welcome dinner inviting community organizations, educator fellows, and principals for relationship building and context setting.
- April 2022: Workshops begin for youth fellows.
- Coaching and Project-Based Learning workshops begin for educator fellows.

Listening & Learning (Fellowship Phase 2)

Summer 2022

- Youth fellows meet with cooperative entrepreneurs and practitioners, including leaders from Co-op City, Cooperative Home Care Associates, Bluestockings Cooperative, Radiate Consulting, Amalgamated Housing Cooperative, and the Lower East Side People's Federal Credit Union.
- Late spring/early summer dinner for school leaders and educators to reflect and share on fellowship to date.



Synthesis & Design (Fellowship Phase 3)

Fall 2022

- Youth fellows attend mini retreat with Rebellious Root to reflect on their time with cooperative practitioners and develop school-based recommendations.
- Co-Creation with youth of Fellowship [reportback](#) with recommendations and action steps for implementing economic democracy in high schools. Fellows present out to their school communities, both peers and teachers.

January 2023

- Public celebration and presentation of final report.
- [Link to mobile-optimized site](#) with links to all public fellowship materials (<https://msha.ke/bxcoops>).

Impact: Youth Fellows

- Fellows reported a range of lessons learned from the program. Many youth leaders gained a clearer understanding of the economy and their power to influence it. They studied community development, connected with local entrepreneurs about their work, and applied critical thinking skills in real world settings. They were exposed to Bronx history and encouraged to take an active role in shaping its future.
- One central organizing activity was student engagement with and contributing to the [Bronx Wide Plan](#): the suggestions from the students about next steps for how to implement these values in their schools led to the development of a proposal for economic democracy schools to be included in the [first round of proposals for public feedback](#) in 2022 and 2023. This work evoked reflections by the youth fellows at the end of the fellowship which pointed both to new learning, as well as the impetus to take action.
- Students tried to design ways of applying these takeaways to their schools. They put forward proposals that would spread resources among their communities in a more democratic way.
- Many expressed excitement at the idea of investing in community outings, events, and trips to gain more insights for themselves, but mostly as a way for their peers to join them in learning about these values and practices in their community. Others proposed starting an economic democracy club or class so students could learn the basics of financial education and cooperative economics.
- Creating a pipeline of student work opportunities to increase collaboration with Bronx co-ops was another popular idea. Youth fellows were excited to learn how to build and operate co-operative businesses.

Impact: Educators

- **School-Community connection:** One of the top motivating factors for getting schools involved in the fellowship arose from something that came up in focus groups: the desire for greater ongoing school community collaboration and connection that was grounded in something that also was applied and involved “real world learning” according to educators (principles, assistant principals, and educators). The fellowship was able to provide that, and then capture some of those activities into a [draft set of activities](#) for the schools (and others in the Bronx or New York City) to borrow and adapt.
- **Real World Learning:** While the current active trends toward work-based learning and college and career readiness have plenty of downsides, the integration of learning outside the classroom with what happens inside the school and the classroom was seen as a big advantage and desirable characteristic of the fellowship by the educators.
- **Work-Based Learning:** While only one of the schools in the cohort was officially a Career and Technical school (known as CTE in New York City), the educators saw the strong potential in the possibility of placements for high school students in cooperative enterprises and organizations. The biggest obstacle to this is the lack of suitable cooperative worksites and a concurrent supervisory and structured capacity to ensure a positive learning environment and a value-add for all involved. This remains probably one of the biggest shortcomings in the New York City landscape: the lack of stable cooperative enterprises or community support organizations to provide a positive structured work-based learning environment for young people.
- **Thematic Differentiation:** As the fellowship came to a close, educators felt excited by the possibility of expansion and tracking of the experiences available to students based on their interest. The two main “buckets” identified for such an expansion were essentially:
 1. social studies, civics, and economics, which would focus on history, community development, real estate, finance, and economic development; and
 2. STEM/tech: which would integrate concepts of science/technology, and society curricula into questions of ownership and technology development for a



more democratic and equitable society. The idea behind these two buckets was not to be comprehensive, but to help students with more choices based on their own understanding of their interests, or to try something new.

Impact: BCDI

- **Identifying unit and system change leverage points:** Identifying the **school**, rather than the individual, as the unit of change means that one fellowship cohort is a beginning step towards observable changes in institutional practices. This first round effort now acts as an established pillar around which to bring more educators and young people into similar and different learning experiences, and reach new audiences. Working with principals and educator fellows, we collectively determined that our approach to scale was to deepen collaborative work with the schools we already are connected with, rather than to immediately seek out new school partners to convey an appearance of rapid “scaling up”.
- **Need for division of labor and roles:** Throughout the fellowship, BCDI needed to maintain clarity about the difference between the role we were playing in the fellowship, which was more direct programmatic coordination and management, compared with the ideal future state, in which BCDI would act as a convener and change management partner for community organizations, cooperatives, and schools to craft these engagements together, with some facilitative support from BCDI. As an organization, BCDI does not see itself directly entering the youth programming or youth services role, which is already widely available from a number of our partner organizations, with their own years of expertise and experience. This may or may not have relevance to other locations and contexts.
- **Resourcing network and communities of practice:** As the fellowship concluded, not only were the individual students and educators in different places in terms of their excitement and interests, but the schools were too. Having the flexibility of allowing different schools to pursue their own experiments creates more opportunities for learning, but is harder to facilitate because it requires more tailored attention and support. Individualized coaching was vastly more appreciated by the educators than the PBL workshops, particularly for more experienced teachers. Early stage teachers appreciated both equally.
- **Investing in teacher training and professional development:** Teachers expressed a strong desire for more opportunities for themselves to understand economic democracy better, not just to experience it secondhand from their students. There were aspects of our program that could stay the same, and some that would



change, with the shift of focus to teacher training and fellowship, as opposed to a “whole school” or youth-oriented approach. The idea of a summer institute for economic democracy for teachers was suggested and appealing to several of our teacher fellows.

What's Next

This fellowship was executed with a budget of \$37,000 from a small discretionary grant. Needless to say, this was not sufficient to cover the full costs, which were absorbed by other BCDI operating funds. We continue to work with our partner organizations and schools to develop next steps that integrate this work into our Bronx Wide economic development plan, as well as provide opportunities for thematic integration and differentiation with STEM and community innovation leadership.

The knowledge and insights that we surfaced are immense, and we're overwhelmed and humbled by the many directions available to us for next steps. The experience of the last several years has brought clarity to our belief that school-community partnerships are a vital site and incubator for movement building for economic democracy.

Part of our learning in this process is that there is an emerging opportunity locally and nationally to bring diverse sectors together to further develop the idea of economic democracy educational "pathways" that connect early childhood learning to career exploration, workforce development, entrepreneurial skillbuilding, and deeper civic and democratic organizational skills and sensibilities. Orienting more actively around the K-12 space would greatly amplify the existing and growing efforts at the undergraduate and graduate levels, where a wide range of offerings in economics, policy, social work, and specialized fields such as law, finance, and real estate, and beginning to create space for more equitable and democratic approaches in their sectors.

During this process, as the fellowship was underway, we began to scout and interview a group of national organizations such as The Institute for the Study of Employee Ownership and Profit Sharing at the Rutgers School of Management and Labor Relations, The Community and Worker Ownership Project at the City University of New York's School of Labor and Urban Studies, the US Federation of Worker Cooperatives, and the American Sustainable Business Network, to gauge interest in a larger national field-building project aimed at surfacing and supporting diverse youth-focused and school-based educational interventions that prepare students to practice economic democracy across the U.S. [In November 2022](#), we hosted a webinar on educating for economic democracy for those in higher education in order to further gauge interest among faculty from a diverse range of disciplines in incorporating concepts of worker ownership and economic democracy into their classrooms. We will continue to follow up



to bring together interested educators from all levels to support their efforts to organize and embed these concepts into their educational institutions. This national work is an important complement to the local and place-based work: the two can and must be mutually reinforcing in order to succeed and grow.

ABOUT BCDI

The Bronx Cooperative Development Initiative (BCDI) is a community-led economic development organization committed to creating shared wealth and ownership for low-income people of color. Local Bronx community-based organizations founded BCDI in 2011 because we saw that, despite persistent and powerful community organizing campaigns, our members continued to get poorer over the preceding decades. We realized we needed new tools to shape the economic trajectory of the Bronx and a strategy to fight forward for a just and prosperous Bronx, while we continued to fight back against injustice. We are growing a network of community and labor organizations, anchor institutions, and small businesses to build an equitable, sustainable, and democratic local economy that creates economic democracy – shared wealth and decision-making power for low-income people of color. Grounded in a movement building approach to economic transformation and a community enterprise network model, we create people-centered planning and development processes; generate community solutions through innovation and digital fabrication technology; develop, grow, and connect local Bronx businesses to new opportunities; and train leaders from across sectors to advance a more democratic Bronx economy.